however, if these negotiations occurred at all, they usually took place at the local level, between village administrators and members of armed groups, while higher-level subcommissions, and even the central UEC, could be entirely unaware of them.

The elections' postponement is based on UEC law section 10f and section 50 of the electoral laws.[8] The language of these laws, as in many areas of the electoral legal framework, is ambiguous, and vulnerable to different interpretations. Sections 10f and 50 establish that the UEC has the authority to postpone elections in constituencies where a natural disaster prevents them, or where the security situation makes voter list updates and polling impossible. While the 'security situation' is not further clarified, the laws state that elections can be partially cancelled within a constituency, and that results from such constituencies are valid if fifty-one per cent of all enrolled constituents participate in the elections. Excluding eligible voters in conflict areas and only needing fifty-one per cent of registered voters to hold an election increases malapportionment, with the potential of creating easy-to-win seats. The natural disasters during the 2015 rainy season did not result in election postponement. All cancellations in 2015 were for security reasons.

UEC public communications did little to clarify the reason for cancellations beyond a simple reference to security. The ambiguity of this language, the lack of public communications and transparent decision-making, or of a publicized participatory approach that would involve various stakeholders led to speculation about the potentially arbitrary or politically motivated nature of these decisions. Such assumptions are grounded in past electoral experiences. Partial cancellations are related to concerns about the potential misuse of advance votes (often of military voters) and about candidates using the influence of local militia to coerce voters. Allegations like this occurred in ceasefire areas where, from the perspective of the voters affected by the cancellations (for example, in Kyainseikgyi), there were no obvious security threats (see HURFOM 2015).

Relative to 2010, and as a result of new or renewed bilateral ceasefires, the southeast witnessed significant improvements to its 2015 electoral space. Most Kayah State townships were affected by cancellations in 2010, but none were in 2015. In Mon State, the nine village tracts without elections in 2010 were reduced to one. In Kayin State, the electoral space increased by approximately a third over this period.[9] Shan State is the only place where cancellations also led to vacant seats in the legislature, and the